

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 18



CHAPTER 18



THE *ASTREA* TO THE RESCUE

When Nat went aboard the *Astrea*, two sailors handled his gear for him, staggering under the weight of an extra sea chest.

Mr. Collins said, "What have we here, Mr. Bowditch? A private store of cannon balls?"

"Books and charts," Nat told him. "I'm starting now to check every figure in every table that's published. Just to see how many errors are in them."

Collins stared. "Man, that'll take you a year!"

"I'll be lucky if it doesn't take three years."

"But why in the name of sense should you slave over —"

Nat bellowed, "Because they ought to be right! That's why!" He started for the companionway. Someone in

ducks and a striped jersey grinned and saluted. For a moment Nat didn't recognize him. "Johnny!"

Johnny swaggered. "Johnny Gorman, able seaman, sir!"

"Congratulations!" Nat told him. He hoped Prince wouldn't feel too bad about the loss of a cabin boy. He was going to feel bad enough about the loss of Lem. He went below, stowed his gear, and returned to the deck. Tom Owens was busy at one of the guns. Maybe Tom would console Prince about the loss of Lem; Tom was a mighty handy man, too, with the guns.

Once more the crew froze to attention; once more Captain Prince came on board, and whipped that stern glance around, seeing everything, looking at no one.

It's just his go-to-sea face, I guess, Nat decided. He probably won't smile between here and Cadiz.

Nat was right; he didn't.

A month later Spain loomed on the horizon. A blockade of British ships stood between the *Astrea* and the harbor of Cadiz. Captain Prince answered the hail of a British ship, ordered his longboat overside, and he and Nat went to present their papers to the British captain.

The Englishman scanned their papers, asked dozens of questions, and gave them a pass to enter Cadiz and trade. "Watch out for French spies," he told them. "They're everywhere. We even found a Frenchman in one of our crews, with a plot to blow up our powder room. Luckily, his pronunciation gave him away."

"The way he'd say — well — for instance, 'commencement'?" And Nat gave the word its French pronunciation.

The British captain raised his eyebrows. "Exactly. You mean, you speak French?" He looked at Prince.

"Congratulations, sir, on having an educated man on board. Not the usual thing on a — a — merchant ship, you know."

Prince's eyes glinted. He was probably thinking that what the Englishman almost said was, "Not the usual thing on an American ship." He drawled, "Yes, an educated man is handy. For instance — when there are errors in Moore, he can find them."

“Errors in Moore!” The Englishman stared.

“Not really Moore’s fault,” Prince said soothingly. “The mistakes were in one of Maskelyne’s tables.” And he returned to the *Astrea* looking very pleased with himself. “Mr. Collins, call the men aft — down to the last one — even the cabin boy!”

The men gathered. Little Charlie Waldo, the new cabin boy, listened big-eyed while Prince explained the danger of French spies. “Mr. Bowditch will tell you how you can spot them by their accent. Keep your ears cocked. If a man with that accent wants to come aboard for any reason — call Mr. Bowditch.”

As Nat explained, he watched Charlie's face. I'll bet, he thought, Charlie finds himself a spy before we leave Cadiz.

The next day when they anchored off Cadiz the health officers came aboard. Nat saw Charlie edging around, his head cocked, listening. Then something jerked Nat's attention from Charlie. The Spanish officer picked up their logbook in one gloved hand, wheeled, and tossed it overboard.

Nat roared at him in Spanish. The health officer smiled and explained. They always dumped logbooks overboard. Didn't the señor know that salt water would

purify the book and banish disease? They fished up the book, dripping wet, scanned it, and bowed to Nat. Everything was in order and safe. The *Astrea* could trade with Cadiz.

That night Nat smiled when he wrote to Elizabeth about the salt-water cure for their logbook. He was glad when he had things like that to tell her.

The next night, after he had visited Cadiz, he had things he could tell her, too — about the city of stone, built on a rocky promontory, jutting out into the blue sea.

They must whitewash every building every year. Everything is so white that the glare hurts your eyes. The streets are so narrow, and the buildings so tall that you feel hemmed in when you walk here. No wonder they have such tall buildings, though. They have nowhere to go but *up*.

He stopped writing, and stared at the paper. When would Elizabeth get this letter, he wondered? No chance to send it back to her, unless they hailed a ship coming from the Mediterranean, going back to America. Maybe he'd just have to carry it home, and they'd read it together. When he got home . . . Nat sighed. Already the time seemed long. He laid his letter aside and went on deck for a walk before he turned in.

Charlie Waldo was on deck, talking to himself.

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“Good for you, Charlie,” Nat said, “you have that French accent, all right. You won’t miss them if they come prowling around, will you?”

Charlie smiled, and bent his head to wipe his wrist over one cheek. In the moonlight Nat could see the youngster’s tearstained face. Poor tad, he was homesick.

“Charlie, I wonder if you could do something for me?”

“Aye, aye, sir!”

“I’m working on a problem in navigation. I’d like to explain it to you. If I can make you understand, I’ll know I’ve got it.”

“Aye, aye, sir! Anything to help!”

They walked the deck while Nat explained. Charlie was quick. He got the explanation much faster than grown men generally did.

“Thank you, Charlie. That’s helped.”

“Thank you, Mr. Bowditch, sir. You don’t know, but you helped me, too!” Charlie grinned and went below, still muttering his words with the misplaced accent.

One morning during their second week in Cadiz, when Nat was in Prince’s cabin, Charlie came to them, goggle-eyed. “We’ve got him, sir! A French spy! I can tell by the way he talks!”

Captain Prince's mouth twitched. "Come, Mr. Bowditch." They went on deck. Charlie was right. The erect, soldiery-looking man did have a French accent.

He was Count Mallevant, he told them — once of the French navy. He had fled to Spain during the French Revolution. Nat knew that Charlie's sigh of disappointment came from his heels.

Count Mallevant said, "I understand there is a scholar aboard this American ship — who is interested in astronomy. A very great scholar who has discovered a new way to work lunars."

Prince nodded toward Nat. "There's your very great scholar — Nathaniel Bowditch."

Mallevant invited Nat to visit the new observatory at Cadiz.

When the count had gone, Prince bowed solemnly. "How-do-you-do, scholar."

Nat laughed, but he felt the same warm flood of happiness he had felt when Dr. Holyoke called him an astronomer. He couldn't explain how he felt to a grown man, though — what it was to remember when he was twelve and found he'd never go to school again. *Nathaniel Bowditch — indentured.* He shrugged off the memory.

That night, when he stood in the observatory, he wished that he could tell Elizabeth what it was like to be there — looking through the telescope that seemed to bring the moon and stars close enough to touch. It was late when he returned to the *Astrea*, but he wrote to her. “You seemed very near when I looked at the moon. Because I knew you could see it, too.” He smiled at that sentence, pleased. Maybe he’d learn to say things the way he wanted to some day!

“All hands on deck!” He heard the yell and jumped to his feet. Dimly he realized he’d been hearing the boom of cannon in the distance. He hurried topside.

The gunfire was coming from the British fleet. What had happened? Was Napoleon attacking? He was supposed to be somewhere in the Mediterranean.

The deck of the *Astrea* was alive with action — men running to secure battle lanterns — to loosen the guns. Presently a boat approached them and a British officer came on board. He was smiling and almost too excited to talk.

“Nelson has trounced Napoleon’s fleet! In the mouth of the Nile! We’ve got him now! Bottled up in Africa!”

So it was just a celebration. Tom Owens growled, "Secure your guns!" Nat smiled at the words. Tom sounded as disgusted as Lem Harvey would have been.

The Englishman said again, "Bottled up in Africa! No more trouble with Napoleon . . . I hope."

"What about the French privateers in the Mediterranean?" Prince asked. "We're standing out of Cadiz for Alicante soon."

"Into the Mediterranean? You'll be safer in convoy with our fleet."

So the *Astrea*, and some four hundred other vessels, started in a vast convoy, guarded by British warships. It was not long before the lookout on the *Astrea* saw three small vessels dropping astern.

Collins leveled his glass. The lagging vessels were American. "What are the fools up to?" he muttered.

Prince studied them, too. "They're too heavy laden to keep up. Scuppers under — the lot of them. Serve them right if . . . " Then he said, "Bring her about, Mr. Collins."

"Aye, aye, sir."

There was no hesitation from the first mate, or from any of the crew as they fell to with a will, to bring the *Astrea* about. They left the protection of the convoy and headed back toward the floundering little vessels. When the *Astrea* was close enough to speak the ships, Captain

Prince hailed them. The *Astrea*, he told them, had nineteen guns, and a crew that could use them. Cheers rose from the little ships.

Tom Owens swaggered and grinned. "One-man convoy! That's what we are!" Nat smiled to himself. Lem Harvey wasn't the only man "born for a fight."

For two days the *Astrea* trimmed sail to the speed of the floundering vessels. Tom began muttering under his breath. What was the use, he wanted to know, wallowing along with fools who didn't know how to sail? "They couldn't make six knots in a trade wind!" he grumbled. "They don't deserve — "

The lookout's singsong, "Sail ho-o-o-o-o-o!" froze every man in his tracks.

Then, with a glad bellow, Tom leaped for the guns. Captain Prince came on deck and leveled his glass. "Three of them," he said, "and flying French colors."

There was no doubt about the colors — or the intentions — of the three ships. They were altering their course, bearing straight down on the *Astrea*. When the decks were cleared, the guns bowsed out, Prince went below with Nat.

Prince opened the logbook and picked up a quill. "Better note this now," he said dryly. "May be a little rushed later." He made the entry and dusted the ink with sand. "We'll need someone in the powder room when things start," he said.

Nat sat down and pulled off his shoes. He knew the danger of a scuffed nail's striking a spark and setting off the powder. "I can take care of the powder room."

Prince frowned and started to speak. Then he shrugged. "Why not? I was going to say we can't risk having our navigator blown to bits. You know, if the powder room gets a direct hit—it goes. But if the powder room's blown to bits, the *Astrea* won't need a navigator, will she? Carry on, Mr. Bowditch." He went topside.

Nat went to the powder room, blinking in the gloom.

The only light there came from a small round window into the next cabin. For a moment Nat was disappointed. He'd thought of getting a little work done while he waited. He'd forgotten they couldn't risk candles or lanterns near the kegs and bags of powder.

Johnny was there, sloshing down the floor with water. "They say it helps some. Of course, if that tier of kegs got a direct hit . . . " He shrugged and grinned. "Good luck, Mr. Bowditch, sir!"

Nat's eyes grew accustomed to the dim glow. It really wasn't too dark, he decided. And no use just sitting there twiddling his thumbs till they needed him to hand up powder. He went to his cabin and got his slate and pencil.

The next thing he heard was Prince's bellow. He started and jumped to his feet. "Aye, aye, sir! You ready for powder?"

Prince said, "The Frenchies didn't like our guns. They got close enough for a good look, then crowded sail and cleared out. Tom's disgusted. Sorry I forgot about you and left you down here so long."

"Long?"

"Great guns, man, you've been here three hours!"

"You're sure, sir?"

Prince broke out in a roar of laughter that brought Collins below. Prince told him the joke. "I give up! I've been through a lot in my day, but I never before saw a man huddle on a powder keg and forget where he was for three hours. That's one for your letter to Elizabeth!"

Nat shook his head. "She might worry, sir."

"Take my advice and tell her," Collins said. "You're married a long time, you know. And women always hear

everything, sooner or later. If you skip anything, some kind friend is sure to say, 'Did your husband ever tell you about the time . . . ' So you tell her first — the way you want her to hear it."

Your husband . . . Nat smiled at the sound of that. He closed the powder room and dogged shut the door, and went for his shoes. In his cabin, he returned to his work. Nothing for him to do now until Alicante.

They had been off Alicante about a week when a ship flying the American flag anchored near them — the *Ember*, from Salem, Captain Gorman commanding. Nat hadn't realized how glad he'd be to see someone from home until Captain Gorman came on board the *Astrea*.

Captain Gorman did not seem half so glad to see Nat. He nodded abruptly and said, "Captain Prince, I'd like to see you below."

Nat felt his temper rising, but he shrugged off his anger. Captain Gorman probably had something on his mind. He'd be in a better mood after he had talked to Captain Prince.

Charlie came to him, frowning with importance. "The captain's compliments, Mr. Bowditch. He'll see you below."

When Nat entered the cabin, Prince said, "Sit down, Nat, sit down, boy."

Captain Gorman sat with head bowed, his elbows on his knees, staring at nothing. Prince strode up and down the cabin a few turns. "I'm — I'm not going to stand off and on about this, Nat. Elizabeth — your wife — is dead."

Captain Gorman said, "That's all I know, Mr. Bow-

ditch. A ship passed me that had left Salem later than we had. They gave me the word."

Nat didn't know when they went out. He realized finally that he was alone and the cabin was growing dark. Eight bells sounded. He had offered to take the anchor watch. He went topside.

Mr. Collins said, "You've been relieved, Mr. Bowditch."

Nat thanked him and went forward to the bow. For a long time he stood there, staring at the sky. The moon rose and made a glittering path on the water. Nat found himself staring down into the water. How deep was it, he wondered . . .

Charlie Waldo spoke at his elbow. "Mr. Bowditch, sir?"

Nat stiffened. "Yes? What is it?"

"I need you, sir. Could you help me, please? This navigation I'm trying to learn . . ."

"Of course, Charlie. Come along to my cabin." For an hour he worked with Charlie over the problem that had stumped him — explaining this way and that, until the boy understood.

"I have it now, sir! Thank you!"

"Thank you, Charlie Waldo. You may not know, but you've helped me, too."

He went topside again, and found Mr. Collins. "I'll stand the next anchor watch," he said. "I don't seem particularly sleepy."

Collins nodded. "Right, Mr. Bowditch." He was silent for a moment; then he went on quietly, "I remember when I lost my wife. Work helped."